

Narrative Control & Workshop System — Inkglass Odyssey

Design document. Read before working on relay/narrative/, relay/admin/, workshop endpoints, or plot beat logic.

Canonical specification for full endpoint schemas and UI behaviour: docs/narrative-control-ui.pdf. This document supplements the spec with architectural decisions made after its publication.

Access Model

Interface	Access	Scope
Admin Workshop	World authors only (ADMIN_MODE=true, never in distributed builds)	Global defaults for a world across all players and rooms
DM Workshop	Multiplayer room host only (role: "dm" session token)	Room-local state only; reads from global defaults, writes to room_state overlay
Narrative Control Panel	Solo player only	Player's own persistent world state only

Access tiers are enforced at the relay layer, not the Unity UI layer. The relay validates the requesting session's role before processing any workshop or panel write. Attempting to write outside scope returns 403 with a descriptive error.

Content Override Model

Global defaults live in the repo as authored content files. Two overlay mechanisms:

DM edits: create a room_state overlay stored against the session_id — a deep copy of defaults modified locally. Quarantined to the room. Archived when session ends. Global defaults never touched by DM actions.

Solo player edits: create player-local overrides stored in the relay database, keyed to

player_id + world_id. The relay resolves content by checking overrides first, then falling back to defaults.

Reset is deletion of the overlay — the defaults show through again.

Visual State Indicators

Every content entry in any Workshop interface displays one of three states:

- **Unmodified default** — no special indicator
- **Modified default** — gains a “reset to default” button and a “compare to original” option
- **User-created addition** — reset deletes it entirely

This three-state indicator is mandatory in all Workshop UIs.

Multiplayer DM Assignment

The player who calls POST /session/start with mode: “multiplayer” receives a session token with role: “dm”. All others get role: “player” with no Workshop access. DM status cannot be transferred mid-session (Phase 3+ consideration).

DM Scope Isolation

When a multiplayer room initialises, the relay creates a room_state document that deep-copies global defaults. All DM writes modify this copy only. When the session ends, room_state is archived as part of the session record. Global defaults are never touched by DM actions.

DM can: adjust NPC emotional state and relationship scores, add/adjust/suppress/trigger plot beats, add room-local quests, mark objectives, view/set world-state flags (with dependency warnings), view player states.

DM cannot: edit NPC personality files, system prompts, or few-shot examples mid-session. Those are global defaults requiring Admin Workshop access.

Narrative Control Panel (Solo)

Accessible from the in-game pause menu under a Story tab (not visible in multiplayer). Interface is written for players, not developers.

Plot beat timeline: horizontal scrollable cards. Players can reorder (converts absolute timing to sequence), suppress, add from curated optional library, and manually trigger

events. Default events can be suppressed but not removed. Manual triggering processes through the relay exactly as scheduled firing would.

Story state view: read-only summary of world-state flags, companions, NPC relationships, completed scenarios. Players cannot directly edit flags — state changes happen through plot beat management or world reset.

Companion dismissal: triggers farewell_template narrative event, not silent deletion.

World Reset

Located at bottom of Story tab, visually separated, cautionary styling.

Two-step confirmation: POST /reset returns a reset_token with 60-second TTL. POST /reset/confirm requires the token plus character name typed by the player.

On confirmation, the relay atomically:

1. Archives current world state as timestamped snapshot (retained 7 days)
2. Writes world defaults to player's state
3. Clears scene records and session summaries
4. Resets NPC memory to first_meeting_template state

Preserved through reset: character sheet (name, appearance, abilities, rp_voice_notes). Only story progress is cleared, not the character itself.

Companion reunion: after reset, if the player previously completed a companion's recruitment scenario (in archived snapshot), the relay offers fast-track reunion via the companion's reunion_template.

Few-Shot Example Minimums

- Admin Workshop (global defaults): minimum **five** voice examples per NPC
- DM Workshop (room-local NPCs): minimum **two** voice examples per NPC
- Both: minimum **one** manipulation-resistance example
- CI validates five-minimum for committed files; DM Workshop validates two-minimum at save time

Admin Interface (Development Tool)

Located at relay/admin/, serves a static HTML/JS frontend on port 8081. Two sections:

RP Tester: interactive testing surface for the dialogue system. Connects to the relay's actual WebSocket and HTTP endpoints using the standard protocol. Exposes: first-call analysis, relay validation changes, second-call prose output, committed scene state. Build as soon as WebSocket dialogue endpoint is functional in Phase 0.

Library Workshop: schema-driven form-based content editor. Users never see JSON. Templates pre-fill per world and content type. Duplicate and inline-create for cross-referenced content.

Hot-reload requirement: saving a content file in the Workshop must be picked up by the relay without restart. Either file-watching or POST /admin/reload/{content_type}.

Data plane separation: Workshop reads/writes filesystem (authoring plane). RP Tester operates against relay runtime (session plane). These must never cross.